

User Stories

- What are User Stories?
- Users and user roles
- Why User Stories?

Requirements

- To facilitate incremental scheduling, requirements should ideally demonstrate the following characteristics:
 - Independent
 - Requirements should be defined independent of each other so that their functionality can be demonstrated independent of the availability of other functionality.
 - For functionality that cannot be isolated, dependencies need to be taken into account when scheduling an increment plan.
 - Demonstrate value
 - The development of a requirement should lead to value that can be demonstrated to the customer/client.
 - Appropriately sized
 - Requirements should be no shorter than half a day and no longer than the length of an increment.

Requirements – Practical Viewpoints

- Good ideas for features emerge throughout the project, not just at the beginning when requirements are gathered
- When customers see working software, they identify lots of changes and improvements they'd like to make
- Our customer's business is constantly evolving, and this causes their requirements to change
- There is a lot of miscommunication and misunderstanding – between the team and their customer, or between the customer and their stakeholder – and often this is only spotted when we see working software
- What we design can't always be built, and what we build often doesn't work the first time, so changes must be made
- We are human, and we often forget or overlook things

Psychology of User Stories

- Software requirements is a communication problem
- What problem do stories address?
 - Those who want the software must communicate with those who will build it
- We need a way of working together so that resource allocation becomes a shared problem
- Project fails when the problem of resource allocation falls too far to one side
- We cannot perfectly predict a software schedule
 - As users see the software, they come up with new ideas
 - Too many intangibles
 - Developers have a notoriously hard time estimating
 - If we can't perfectly predict a schedule, we can't perfectly say what will be delivered

The Paradigm Shift

We make decisions
based on the
information we have

... but do it often

Rather than making one
all-encompassing set
Of decisions

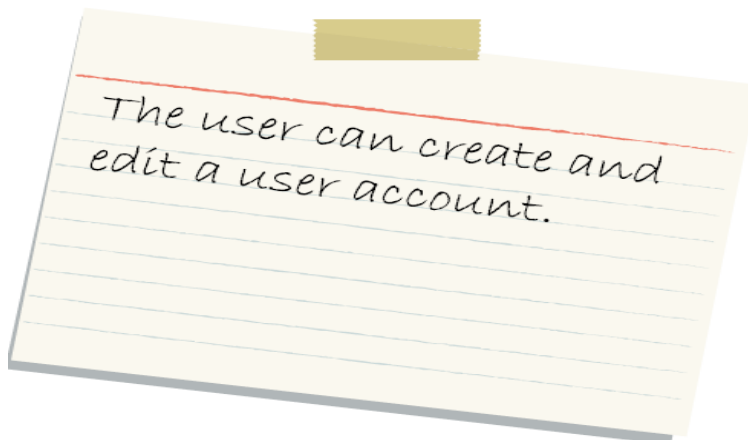
... we spread decision-
making across the
project

This is where
User Stories
come in

User Stories

- Agile methodologies prefer user stories to gather requirements.
- User stories are short written descriptions of desired functionality based on client conversations.
- Lower-level details are left out to ease communication between customer and development and are documented elsewhere (notes, annex, test script, ...) but need to provide sufficient detail to allow accurate estimating.

User stories are often written on cards



We want to focus on building functionality

Req ID	
1.1	Provide the ability to enter a username
1.2	A username can have a maximum length of 25 characters
1.3	A username must be at least 5 characters

What are User Stories?

- 3 Cs
 - Card
 - User stories are conventionally written on cards
 - Although, increasingly software tools are being used.
 - Cards may include estimates, notes, etc.
 - Conversation
 - Details emerge from conversations with product owners
 - Confirmation
 - Acceptable tests confirm correctly coded stories

What are User Stories?

As a user, I want to reserve a hotel room.

As a user, I want to cancel a reservation.

As a vacation planner, I want to see photos of the hotels.

As a frequent flyer, I want to rebook a past trip, so that I save time booking trips I take

Where are the details?

- As a user, I can cancel a reservation.
 - Does the user get a full or partial refund?
 - Is the refund to her credit card or is it site credit?
 - How far ahead must the reservation be cancelled?
 - Is that the same for all hotels?
 - For all site visitors? Can frequent travellers cancel later?
 - Is a confirmation provided to the user?
 - How?

A) Details as Conditions

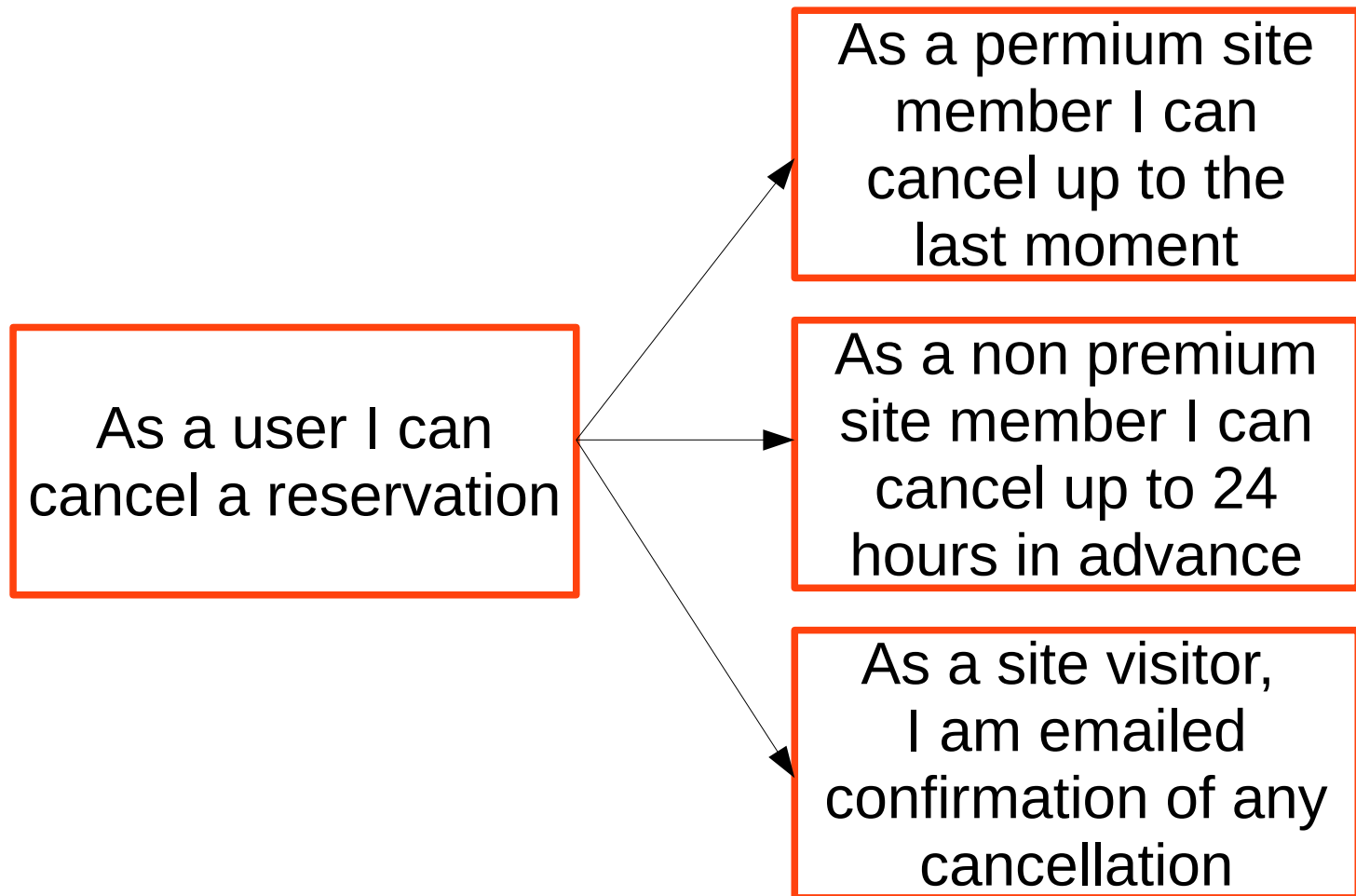
- Conditions of satisfaction can be added to a story
 - These are essentially tests.

As a user, I can cancel a reservation.

- ☐ Verify that a premium member can cancel the same day without a fee.
- ☐ Verify that a non-premium member is charged 10% for a same-day cancellation.
- ☐ Verify that an email confirmation is sent.
- ☐ Verify that the hotel is notified of any cancellation.

B) Details Added to Sub-Stories

- Details can be added to sub-stories



Handling Details

- These techniques can be combined
- The approaches are not mutually exclusive
- At implementation time
 - All stories must have satisfaction conditions

Augment as Necessary

- User stories are not dogma
- Augment them with written documentation as appropriate
 - Business rules
 - Data dictionaries
 - Use cases
 - Examples of inputs and expected result

“The User”

- Many projects mistakenly assume there's only one user:
 - “The user”
- Write all stories from one user's perspective
- Assume all users have the same goals
- Leads to missing stories

User Roles

- Broaden the scope from looking at one user
- Allows users to vary by
 - What they use the software for
 - How they use the software
 - Background
 - Familiarity with the software / computers
- Used extensively in user-centred design

Exercise 1

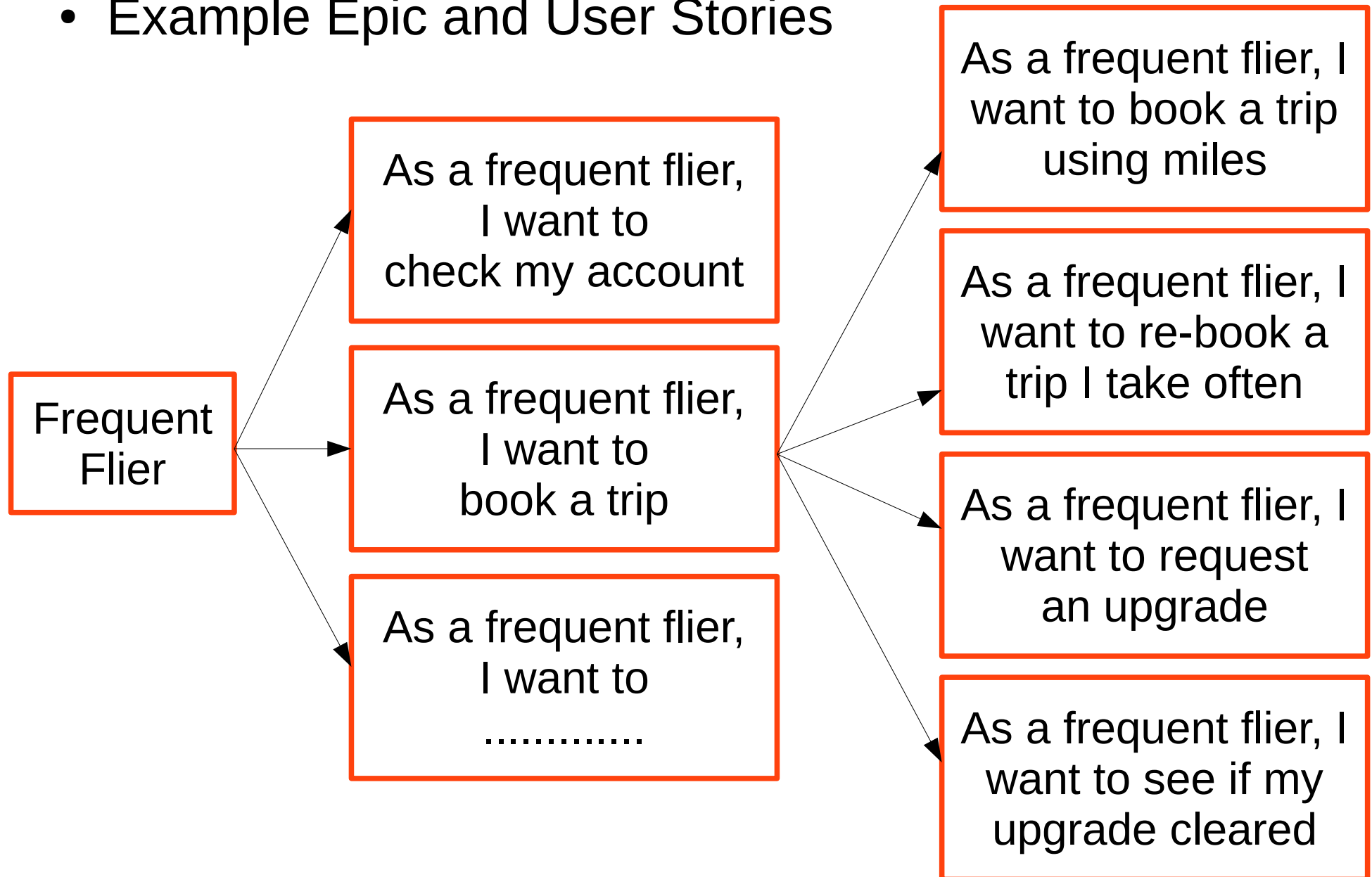
- User Role Brainstorming

We've been hired by to develop a website for the local high school. To get us started they've said they like the school website on the next page.

Brainstorm the user roles who will interact with this site.

Exercise 2

- Example Epic and User Stories



Exercise 2

Start with the roles you've identified. For two or three, Think of their top-level goals and write some epics. Then convert a couple of epics into more usable stories.

Tip:

Try this template:

“As a <user role>, I want <goal> so that <reason>”.

Why User Stories?

Stories shift the focus from writing to talking

Stories emphasize the user's goals not the system's attributes.

Stories are equally understandable by developers and customers

Stories support and encourage iterative development

Stories are the right size for planning

Stories support participatory design